THE HALCYON CYCLE



Books Two through Seven

detailed outlines

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CONTAINS SPOILERS FOR THE ENTIRE SERIES.

THE HALCYON CYCLE — Books Two to Seven: Series Outlines

SPOILER WARNING — AUTHOR ONLY. This document reveals the saga's objective truths and every principal character's fate, including all deaths and the ending of Book Seven. Do not share it with readers or reviewers who should meet the books cold.

Conventions. - This document follows SERIES_ARCHITECTURE.md. Where it adds detail, the architecture's fixed truths take precedence. - (provisional) marks a significant invented element (a name, place, mechanism or event) that is open to revision in drafting. - Rule extension: marks any use of grain-work beyond the letter of MAGIC_SYSTEM.md. Each one needs a DECISIONS.md amendment before it reaches a manuscript. - Ages are given at the start of each book. Hester was born in 870 Y.E. Tib was kept in 892, aged 14. - Each book changes the kind of conflict, as the architecture's table requires: intrigue, expedition, first contact, war, engineering, reckoning. No book is "the academy mystery again, with a stronger villain."

BOOK TWO — THE LANTERN TITHE

Spring to Midsummer 904 Y.E. Conflict: political and institutional intrigue. Hester is 34.

Working title and one-line pitch

The Lantern Tithe. A city fights over who will pay for its light, and Hester learns that a truth won in the dark can be bought, voted down and buried in daylight.

Premise

The Tear, the steaming lake Hester's vent left on the White, has survived the winter. It has fish in it, weed, and one gull that the Tiders have named the Herald. All Ambry walks the Causeway to look at it. The Exchequer files to tax and mine it. The Tiders proclaim the Return. Quell sends envoys to claim a share of the "new water."

To control the story, the Halcyon convenes a Board of Inquiry into the Shelf Event. Deputy Chancellor Vey writes its terms of reference: the Warden's crimes, the safety of the Stays and the commercial status of the Tear. The founding is not among them. Hester, a newly second-year aspirant, is named the Board's Lowside appointee. The appointment placates the Assize and the Lowside Bench, and Vey expects a customs assayer to be easy to manage.

At the same time the Conclave proposes the Lantern Tithe, a tax on kept light to pay for new Stays "after the Warden's crimes." Halcyon-held stock is exempt. The Tithe would fall hardest on Quell glaziers and on Lowside's lantern-carriers.

Themes

- [A] Who owns the truth? Evidence is only as strong as the body allowed to hear it.
- [A] The cost of light. Who is lit, who pays, and who profits from darkness.
- [A] Power is not truth. Hester's B1 victory was physical: she cut a rod and opened a shaft. B2's victories have to be procedural, and she is bad at procedure.

Central conflict

Hester and the reformers (Crisp, Bassano, Sorle and Aske) against Vey and the Seal over one question: may the Inquiry examine the founding? Every other plot (the Tithe, the light hoard, the sabotage) is a move in that contest.

Setting developments

[A]The Tear as a civic place: pilgrim camps, Tider candles and Exchequer survey stakes. A new salt crust forms at its margins.

[A]The Hall of Assay used as a courtroom.

[A]The Proctory cells, where Orsolya is held.

[A]The Founders' Gallery on the Second Fathom, entered at last.

[A]Ambry's Glassmarket and its lantern trade. The Linkmen, Lowside's guild of lantern-carriers (provisional), who light the lower wards for pennies.

[A]The Lantern Harvest at Midsummer: the Lantern's mirrors press a summer's light into the year's jars. It is the counterpart of Bɪ's Lantern Night: autumn spends the light, summer gathers it.

Act-by-act outline

Act I — The Board (spring). - Dawn at the Tear. Hester and Sorle stake out the new crust for measurement while the Herald circles overhead. Sorle forbids himself hope out loud, which is how she knows he has some. - The first session. The Board meets: Vey in the chair, Reader Crisp, an Exchequer assessor, a Lodge observer (provisional: Envoy Marit Halvard of Quell) and Hester. Hester moves to examine the Founders' Shaft. The motion fails 4–1. She learns what a quorum is by losing one. - Aske, legally dead. Aske is recovering in the Physic wards with a stiff right hand. He cannot pinch grain or cut brinescript. Under the Stillborn clause his estate, including his notebooks, has passed to the Halcyon, and he must petition the Proctory Court to be declared alive (provisional). The petition runs as a bleakly comic thread through the book. - Orsolya's trial. At the Proctory trial Hester testifies, and Orsolya pleads guilty to keeping Aske. She names no one. Aske speaks in mitigation, to the court's astonishment: "She meant it as a pause. I have had a pause. I recommend against it." Orsolya is sentenced to confinement in the Proctory cells at the Chancellor's pleasure. From her cell she gives Hester one question: *"Ask them why the Cistern has a valve at both ends."* - Dunmore traced. Daisy Fenn pulls the Dry Harbour manifests and finds that Dunmore fled east on a Ferrers freighter. Lucan, now working as a secretary in

his father's Exchequer office, finds that the passage was booked through the Deputy Chancellor's office. The Concord watch takes Dunmore at the Ostmere passes. His deposition: Vey knew of the draw by Cinder 903 and let it run, because the Stays needed it. Gage, shaken, privately confirms to Hester that Vey ordered the rod lost.

Act II — Light (late spring). - The price of light. Lantern prices triple. The Linkmen cannot afford stock, and Lowside goes dark at night: thefts, a drowning in a brine-pit, a child lost in the Pans. Vey sells the Tithe as a safety measure. - The Lodge's offer. Envoy Halvard offers Saskia a paid Lodge fellowship and Pip's school fees. In return she is to report on the Inquiry. Saskia takes the first payment, because her rent is due. - Saskia's clue. Working the Halcyon light-presses under Bassano, Saskia reads the light in jars sold in the Glassmarket as "Quell stock." Her colour-fringe sense shows the double fringe of the Lantern's mirrors (provisional): this is Halcyon-pressed light from summer 903. Someone is buying Halcyon light and selling it through Quell fronts, so that Quell takes the blame for the hoard. - The ledgers. In the Exchequer ledgers Lucan traces the purchases to a light factor, Harrow & Sons (provisional), paid in Halcyon scrip. The broker is Fennick Rade (provisional), a former Exchequer exciseman. If the Tithe passes, the exemption will make Halcyon-held light the only untaxed light on the Rim. - The explosion. A Glassmarket lantern store explodes when kept light is released too fast and its arrears come out as heat. Hennie Orme's shop is gutted; Pip is unhurt. Ambry blames Quell, and the envoy's lodgings are stoned. - Saskia's choice. She learns that Halvard has been speculating in the hoarded light too: Quell and the Seal are both profiting from Lowside's darkness. She returns the Lodge's money and gives Hester the envoy's letters.

Act III — The Founders' Gallery (early summer). - Smuggling Aske in. Callow tells Hester that the Gallery holds "what the fire was told to spare." Only the Chancellor may enter it. Callow finds a loophole: Aske is still catalogued as Quiet Rooms property, so Callow logs him into the Gallery as an object in transit, with Hester as his porter (provisional). - The night in the Gallery. Aske, relearning his hands, reads brinescript left-handed for the first time. Three finds: 1. The Seal's ledger fragment. A brinescript oath ("We who keep the Keep-

ing") and nine centuries of names, ending with *Holm* and *Vey*. 2. Ysolde's partial journal. The ink pages are burned and the salt impression survives. Its key line is *"the Keeping was the only mercy left us."* It names Ilisse once, in passing: "the bells of Ilisse." 3. The Hush Stay Works (provisional). These are current drawings, in Vey's hand, for a great stay to cap the Founders' Shaft and re-still the Tear. It would be fed by a new draw on the Quiet Rooms' kept-beyond-return persons, the Halcyon's Stillborn property. Hester finds Aske's old casing number on the feed list. The light money pays for it. - Year 0. Sorle and Hester cold-date the Tear's new crust. It reads 0 Y.E. (signature moment 12). The salt is not mineral that formed over nine centuries. It is the moment itself, re-crystallising. Sorle sits on the salt and does not speak for a long time. - Vey closes the doors. The Gallery entry is discovered. Callow is suspended. Hester is removed from the Board for "conflict of interest," because her sponsor's hypothesis is under examination. Without the Chancellor's leave the tablets cannot be entered as evidence. Hester holds the truth and cannot use it. This is the book's dark moment. - The answer. Callow has witnessed sixty years of the Gallery, so he can give kept testimony: a salt-read impression of his own memory of the Seal at work, admissible under the strict rules. It must be entered at a public session.

Act IV — The Lantern Harvest (Midsummer). - The day. The Tithe vote falls on Harvest Day. The Inquiry's last public session is held in the Hall of Assay, with its galleries full of Harvest crowds. - The fire. Rade's men jam the release valves on the Rookery light-presses. The aim is to burn the press-house, which holds the press-records that tie the hoard to the Halcyon, and to blame the Open Grain Circle.

Climax

Lantern Harvest Night. A season's light pours out of the sabotaged presses too fast. It shines white-gold and gives off a killing heat, and the Rookery's upper cells catch fire. - Saskia anneals the release. She paces the light through the cooling channels in timed pulses for three hours, and her hands blister. This is Bi's lesson made her own. - Hester keeps a burning roof-beam to stop a collapse and lags in the smoke. Teo drags her clear. - Teo and Mattie empty the Rookery cell by cell. - The press-records survive. In the Hall below, Crisp enters Callow's kept

testimony. Gage testifies that Vey ordered the rod lost, and Dunmore's deposition is read. The Seal is named in public for the first time. - Then Chancellor Holm, motionless all session, asks to speak. Her whisper is relayed sentence by sentence by a Proctor. "We made the Ebb" (signature moment 13). She claims it was done to end a flood.

Resolution

- [A]Holm resigns that night. She says she alone kept the secret in her generation, which shields Vey. Within the week she sits down in the empty Choir and does not rise (her final Settle; the manner is provisional).
- [A]Vey denies membership of the Seal. He presents himself as the man who will "open the founding to proper inquiry." With the Exchequer's backing, light-money votes and a reform vote split between Crisp and Bassano (provisional), the Conclave elects him Chancellor (signature moment 14).
- [A]The Tithe fails in the Assize. The Hush Stay Works are publicly cancelled. Vey keeps the drawings.
- [A]Sorle's 871 censure is struck from the Conclave record.
- [A]Aske is declared alive.
- [A]Hester is restored to a reconstituted Founding Inquiry, with Saskia as its secretary.
- [A]At the Cold House, Hester tells Tib that the sea was made into salt by people, and that she means to find out how.

Character arcs

- [A]Hester: she learns that power is not truth. She must make allies, count votes and let others speak for her: Callow, Crisp, Saskia. She ends the book more patient and more dangerous.
- [A]Teo: he begins a romance with Mattie, the baker. In the Tear's crust he hears more than "Aelith": faint, regular bells. He tells only Hester.

[A]Saskia: she chooses between the Lodge's money and the Halcyon, and chooses the Halcyon with open eyes. Her annealing at the climax is her first public act of courage.

[A]Lucan: he works inside his father's house as a spy in plain sight. He does not yet break with Aurel. He learns how comfortably his father lives beside Vey's lies.

[A]Aske: he relearns his hands, the left one fluently and the right one partly, and fights to be legally alive. He is funnier and sadder than before.

[A]Sorle: he is vindicated, and finds vindication oddly empty: "I have been right for thirty-three years. It was not the pleasure I was promised."

[A]Orsolya: she is convicted and contained. Her one question about the double valve points Hester toward the founders' intent.

[A]Aldous: after B1's partial reconciliation he comes to the Harvest crowd. He coughs, the first sign of salt-lung.

[A]Holm: she makes her confession, a half-truth, and dies.

[A]New: Envoy Marit Halvard (provisional), a charming opportunist who returns in B3 as the Lodge's political sponsor. Fennick Rade (provisional), Vey's broker, who resurfaces in B6.

Key relationships

[A]Hester and Saskia: from wary B1 allies to sisters-in-arms.

[A]Hester and Lucan: working trust, conducted in coded notes from the Exchequer. Still nothing spoken.

[A]Hester and Vey: open enmity, scrupulously polite.

[A]Aske and Orsolya: victim and keeper in a courtroom, and the beginning of his strange forgiveness.

[A]Sorle and Callow: two old men who outlasted the lie.

Magical discoveries

[A] The Held Moment proven. Sorle's hypothesis, tested by Hester's cold-dating of the Tear's new crust (0 Y.E.).

> Rule extension: salt precipitated from vented sea-water carries the cold-date of the moment it came from, not the date it formed. This sits within Assay's "dating grain," but it needs to be stated in the canon.

[A] The physics of kept light under stress. Too-rapid release discharges arrears as heat (Law 4). Annealing applies to light-presses as it does to glass.

[A] Kept testimony used at its full legal strength.

Political developments

[A] The Seal is publicly exposed.

[A] Holm resigns, and Vey becomes Chancellor.

[A] The Tithe fails. The Linkmen and the Glassmarket emerge as a Lowside–Quell alliance (provisional).

[A] Quell gains standing in Ambry through Saskia's exposure of the false "Quell stock," and Halvard is quietly recalled.

[A] The Exchequer is embarrassed but intact. Aurel Ferrers distances himself from Rade.

[A] The Founding Inquiry is constituted.

Mystery developments

[A] Book mystery: who is buying kept light? Solution: Vey, through Rade and Harrow & Sons. He means to swing the Tithe so that untaxed Halcyon light becomes a fortune, and to fund the Hush Stay Works in secret.

[A] Saga mystery: the Seal exists. The Ebb was made. The salt is the moment. Ysolde called the Keeping a mercy, and named Ilisse. Teo hears bells.

Major revelations, with supporting evidence

1. The Seal exists. B1: Vey leaving Gage's office; the lost rod; Holm unsurprised by the gull; her line "We only hoped to be dead first." B2: Dunmore's deposition; the ledger fragment.
2. The Ebb was made. B1: Sorle's Folly; Orsolya's "it was always meant"; the Brinestacks Fire; the Cistern. B2: Orsolya's double valve; the 0 Y.E. crust; Holm's confession.
3. Vey knew of the draw. B1: Gage "loses" the rod on Vey's order. B2: Dunmore's booked passage; Gage's confirmation.
4. Vey bought the light. Saskia's fringe-reading; Lucan's ledgers; the Tithe's exemption clause.
5. Holm's "to end a flood" is a lie. It is not exposed until B5. Plant the doubt now: Ysolde's word is *mercy*, not *safety*, and Sorle notes that no flood record survives from a fire that spared the Gallery.

Series consequences

[A] The public knows the Ebb was made. It does not know how, or that people are inside it.

[A] Vey is Chancellor and the Seal is publicly dissolved, but Vey keeps its knowledge and its drawings.

[A] The Founding Inquiry exists, with Saskia as secretary.

[A] Ysolde's fragment names Ilisse, and Sorle's proof predicts that the Deep holds the moment's heart. The Conclave and the Lodge propose a joint expedition to sound the Deep. Vey consents in order to control it.

[A] Aske is alive again in law, stiff-handed, and restless.

BOOK THREE — A MAP OF STILL WATER

Autumn 904 to Spring 905 Y.E. Conflict: expedition and exploration. Hester is 34–35.

Working title and one-line pitch

A Map of Still Water. Forty people cross the deadliest country in the world to learn whether a city lies under it, and to decide who gets to tell what they find.

Premise

Sorle's proof says the salt is a held moment, and Ysolde's fragment names "the bells of Ilisse." If both are true, the heart of the moment lies under the Deep, where no expedition has gone and returned with readings.

The Conclave and the Quell Lodge jointly sponsor the Deep Sounding: three landships and forty-one crew (provisional numbers) crossing the White to sound the Deep and find Ilisse if it exists. - The ships: the Halcyon flagship *Harrier*, the Lodge freighter *Glasswing* and the Exchequer survey sledge *Tally* (all provisional). - The command: Aske leads, with Hester as second. - The Exchequer's condition: Aurel Ferrers funds the expedition on two terms. His son sails as Exchequer assessor. All readings go sealed to the Chancellor. - The guides: the Wend.

Saskia stays in Ambry to keep the Founding Inquiry alive against Vey. Her plot runs in parallel through letters.

Themes

- [A]Maps and territory. A map is a claim, not a place. Every faction aboard wants to own the map.
- [A]Belief and evidence. The Wend believe without readings. The Halcyon reads without believing. Teo stands between them.

Central conflict

- [A]Survival on the White: whiteouts, thirst, the Pull, sinks.
- [A]A split expedition: Lodge openness, led by the Quell landship-master Dagny Strand (provisional), against Exchequer secrecy, led by the Exchequer surveyor Merriam Coyle (provisional). The question is whether the readings will be published or sealed.

Aske, who promised both sides everything, must eventually choose.

Setting developments

[A]The open White beyond the Shelf. Polygon tiles a hundred miles wide. Night-chime. Pinkwater wells. Mirage-cities in the Pull.

[A]The Wend. Their brine-well camps, felt sledges and salt-songs. Their sacred rule: *you do not cut the salt where it sings.*

[A]The Sieve (provisional): a sink-field twenty miles across, where the crust is honeycombed over brine.

[A]The 812 survey wreck (provisional): an Exchequer landship lost ninety-two years ago, half-swallowed in the Sieve.

[A]The Deep: in the cold months its salt is glass-clear for fathoms. Darkness lies beneath, and something in the darkness rings.

Act-by-act outline

Act I — Departure (autumn). - The Dry Harbour. The convoy leaves past the Tear. Hester learns that Lucan is the Exchequer's man, and the old contempt flares. "I'm told I'm insufferable." "You're told correctly." - Farewells. Sorle gives Hester his sealed predictions of crust age by distance. She is not to open them until she has her own readings, so the test is blind. Aldous gives her his old pan-hook "for luck," which is the most he has ever said. - The first whiteout. *Tally* is lost for a night. Hester finds her by taste, reading the age-gradient of the crust grain by grain toward the place where the salt is "younger in the wrong direction." It is the first proof of Sorle's predictions: the crust grows *older* toward the margins and *younger*, closer to Year 0, toward the Deep. - Strain in the command. Aske proves a delightful and indecisive commander. Hester covers for him and resents it. Coyle is courteous and always measuring.

Act II — The Wend (early winter). - The brine-well. The convoy meets a Wend band. Their songkeeper is the elder Ennor (provisional), and her grandson Taevo (provisional) is a sink-reader. - The singing. At night the Wend sing to the salt (signature moment 15): slow, breath-locked songs like the Stay Choir's. - Teo learns the chant. Many of the "nonsense" syllables match Ostrin phono-

logy: open vowels, *-ae*, *-ille*. One phrase is close to *Aelith*. - The Wend tradition. The Wend speak of "the people under the white sheet, who are still deciding." They will guide the convoy into the Deep only if no one cuts the salt where it sings. Aske gives his word. Coyle objects on the Exchequer's behalf and is overruled. - Night watch. Hester and Lucan talk. He tells her about his mother's death; she tells him about her father's pans. The romance begins in small things: shared water, an argument about Sorle's mathematics that runs until dawn, and his hand steadying hers on an icy rail, a contact neither mentions. - Saskia's first letters (by post-sledge relay, provisional). Vey is drafting a Deep Reserve Act to make the Deep Charter property. Saskia blocks his attempt to dissolve the Founding Inquiry by having the Assize co-sponsor it.

Act III — Mutiny (midwinter). - The Sieve. Two *Tally* crewmen die in a sink. Taevo reads a safe line through the field tile by tile. - The wreck. The convoy finds the 812 survey wreck. Its brinescript log records "a structure below, regular, as of masonry." It also records the Exchequer's order to suppress the finding. (Saskia's letters confirm it from Ambry: the 812 suppression order bears the Seal's mark.) - Suspicion. Water runs short. Coyle stirs *Tally*'s crew to turn back, and suspicion falls on Lucan: his cabin holds ciphered letters. Hester believes it for one terrible day. The letters are to Saskia, enciphered because Lucan knows the post-sledges are read. - Teo hears the truth. He hears Deep grain *singing* in Coyle's locker. She has been cutting cores at night, against the Wend promise. - The mutiny. Coyle's crew try to take *Tally* and *Harrier*'s water. Aske finally commands: he stands in front of the water casks and orders the mutineers down. Coyle fires a matchlock pistol and the ball takes Aske in the hip. Hester and Dagny Strand disarm the mutineers. Coyle is bound. - The Wend leave. Hearing that the salt has been cut, Ennor's people go, in grief more than anger. Taevo stays, because he wants to see what the songs are about.

Act IV — The Deep (late winter to spring). - Clear salt. Hester, now acting commander, takes the convoy onto the clear salt. Aske's wound festers, and he directs from a cot. - Bells. Soundings drop down fathoms of glass. Teo hears the Roar resolve into bells. Lucan, counting with his rhythm-sense, finds that they ring in a repeating pattern of three-and-one. Teo thinks it is an alarm. - The tower. At dawn, on the third day, a bright point appears far below. Each morn-

ing, as the light improves, it becomes a shape: the bell-tower of Ilisse, sixty fathoms down (signature moment 16). - Sorle's predictions are opened. The crust ages match his figures within a few percent. - The escape. Coyle frees herself in the night. She tries to blast a core out with a sink-charge to take a true Deep sample, and weakens the crust under *Harrier*.

Climax

The sink-collapse. - The crust beneath *Harrier* gives way. The landship, with eleven crew and the wounded Aske aboard, drops into a brine sink above the clear Deep. - Hester has her hands in the bilge-well, where the live brine is rising through the shattered hull, and *keeps the landship mid-plunge* (signature moment 17): the whole ship and the brine around it, held in one casing. It is the greatest hold of her life. - She lags for an hour, effectively dead to the world. - The crew vent her down. Aske directs from his cot, and Lucan counts the release pulses on her rhythm. Teo sings the Wend chant to lock the crew's breaths. Saskia's annealing schedule, carried in Hester's notebook, sets the pacing. They dissolve the casing in stages, lowering the ship onto a shelf of solid salt and bleeding the arrears into the sink. Hester comes back in a rush: racing heart, light too bright. - In the last moment of the plunge, the shattered crust gives the clearest view anyone has had. Through the clear salt they see the tower, a window in it, and a figure at the window: still, upright, one hand raised.

Resolution

[A]The expedition returns in spring with its readings, a drawn map of the tower and the 812 log.

[A]Aske delivers the sealed copy to Chancellor Vey, as contracted. He has already given Dagny Strand the second copy, which he calls "a souvenir." The Lodge presses at Quell print the map within a week.

[A]The Rim learns that there is a city in the salt.

[A]Vey seals the Deep under the Deep Reserve Act and posts Proctors on the margins.

[A]Coyle is handed to the Concord. She confesses that the Exchequer wanted cores to estimate the value of the Deep.

[A]Hester's conflict with the sea is resolved: everyone survives the Deep. Her conflict over the map is resolved in favour of openness.

[A]In a quiet scene on the Dry Harbour quay, she tells Lucan about Tib's *let me sleep*. He does not try to absolve her. That is why she lets him stay.

Character arcs

[A]Hester: from second to commander. She learns that her greatest hold needs other people to let her go. Release is a team art. She begins to trust Lucan.

[A]Teo: he commits to listening. He learns the Wend chant, hears the bells and asks to transfer to Sonance on his return (provisional: under Reader Ilse Varro, Sonance). He is the expedition's ear.

[A]Saskia: she holds the Inquiry together single-handed, outmanoeuvres Vey in the Assize and raises Pip. Her letters, dry and numerical and increasingly affectionate, are the book's second voice.

[A]Lucan: he is falsely suspected and proven loyal. He writes his father a full and true report. Aurel does not answer, which is an answer.

[A]Aske: he takes command too late, is wounded and limps thereafter (provisional: he walks with a stick). On the White he talks wistfully about the shellfish in old paintings. Plant this for his oysters.

[A]Sorle: he stays home. His blind predictions are triumphantly confirmed. Hester's letters note that he has begun to drift, sitting for long intervals without noticing. This is an early Settle sign, and it seeds his B5 death.

[A]Orsolya: before departure Hester visits her cell. Orsolya gives her Whitecraft: "When the tiles stop chiming, chick, the salt's thinking about you." It saves *Harrier* once in Act III.

[A]Aldous: the pan-hook and a farewell. His cough worsens.

[A]New: Dagny Strand (provisional), a laconic Quell master who becomes a long-term ally and the Lodge's voice in B5–B7. Merriam Coyle (provi-

sional). Ennor and Taevo (provisional); Taevo becomes Teo's link to the Wend in B4.

Key relationships

[A]Hester and Lucan: suspicion, then vindication, then confession. The romance begins slowly, adult and wary.

[A]Teo and Taevo: teacher and pupil, who swap roles constantly.

[A]Hester and Aske: the mentor fails and is forgiven.

[A]Saskia and Hester: sisterhood by letter.

[A]Aske and Dagny Strand: conspirators in openness.

Magical discoveries

[A]A drowned city under the salt. It is seen, sounded and mapped.

[A]Bells in the Roar. The Roar is not uniform noise. Specific sounds are kept at specific depths, as the moment's geography.

[A]Crust age falls toward Year 0 toward the Deep, confirming the Held Moment at basin scale.

[A]The Wend chant is a breath-locking technique like the Choir's, preserving Ostrin syllables.

[A]Coring the Deep destabilises the crust. Cutting the moment's overburden invites quickening, which makes the moral and practical case against deep mining.

[A]Rule extension (scale only): a single worker keeping a loaded landship of some sixty tons. No mass ceiling is stated in the canon. The lag (an hour) and the staged venting obey all the existing laws.

Political developments

[A]The Deep Reserve Act seals the Deep under Charter. It is Vey's response to a map he could not suppress.

[A]The Lodge's prestige rises. The Open Grain movement grows in Ambry.

[A]The Exchequer is shamed by Coyle's confession and the 812 log.

[A]The Tiders declare a pilgrimage to the Deep. Vey bans it.

[A]The Founding Inquiry, preserved by Saskia, gains Assize co-sponsorship.

Mystery developments

[A]Book mystery: what is down there, and was Ilisse real? Solution: yes. A drowned island-city lies held in the salt, its tower sixty fathoms down.

[A]Secondary mystery: who is the Exchequer's spy? Solution: Coyle. Lucan is the red herring.

[A]Saga mystery: the figure at the window. Is it a statue, a corpse or a person? Kept dead cloud grey; the figure is clear. Hester notices. She does not yet let herself conclude it.

Major revelations, with supporting evidence

1. There is a city under the Deep. B1: a single bell in the Roar in Ch. 8. B2: Ysolde's "bells of Ilisse"; Teo's bells in the Tear crust. B3: the Wend songs; the 812 log; the soundings.
2. The Wend preserve Ostrin speech. B1: "Aelith." World Bible: Ostrin fragments survive "in the Wend songs." B3: Teo's phonology match.
3. Coyle is the spy. Her coring tools; her insistence on samples at the Wend well; the grain singing in her locker. Lucan's cipher is a planted false trail, resolved by Saskia's matching letters.
4. The Exchequer knew in 812. The wreck's log; the Seal mark Saskia finds in Ambry.
5. The figure is clear, not grey. B1's "the living keep clear, the dead keep grey." This sets up B4.

Series consequences

[A]The Rim knows there is a city in the salt, and the Deep is sealed.

[A]Teo has Deep cores, the Wend chant and a new Bench, and he cannot stop listening.

[A] Hester has seen a figure in a clear casing and knows what clear means.

[A] Hester and Lucan's romance has begun.

[A] Aske is lamed. Sorle is drifting. Aldous is coughing.

BOOK FOUR — THE DROWNED CHOIR

905–906 Y.E. Conflict: first contact and moral crisis. Hester is 35–36.

Working title and one-line pitch

The Drowned Choir. The voices in the salt are people, they have been waiting nine hundred years to learn whether they lost, and every lamp in the Rim is lit with their time.

Premise

Teo, reading the Deep cores, isolates speech in the Roar. It is not echo or ballad. It is a language.

Hester, tasting the boundary of the Tear's salt, realises that kept minds are not absolutely still at a casing's edge. Where the moment has been thinned by quickening and by mining, Ostrin time has crept. Nine hundred years have been, for them, some minutes (provisional figure from Sorle's calculus: about eleven).

The Ostrin are alive and aware, in the middle of a battle. Every dram of grain ever dissolved has spent a sliver of their moment. That includes every lantern, every medicine and every keeping, Tib's among them.

Themes

[A] Complicity. No one on the Rim is innocent of the salt.

[A] Can you apologise across time? And what does an apology owe beyond words?

Central conflict

Whether to halt deep mining and accept economic collapse, or continue and go on consuming a people.

This is not a contest between a hero and a villain. It divides every household. The Brineries need Deep grain to recast their sleepers. A halt means that kept Rim lives, Tib's among them, will run on dwindling stock.

Setting developments

- [A] The Sonance workrooms on the Third Fathom.
- [A] The Choir as the site of contact.
- [A] The Founders' Shaft, reopened under guard: a live-brine column linking the Hush boundary to the Tear.
- [A] The Tider riots in the Mardens and Lowside. Tidewater Abbey.
- [A] The Exchequer Counting House under siege by creditors.
- [A] The Cold House, where Aldous comes for the last time.

Act-by-act outline

Act I — The Listening. - The first word (signature moment 18). In a Deep core from the clear salt, Teo hears a woman's voice say one word again and again, more slowly than any human speech. It is *Aelith*. The rhythm of it lets him strip the Roar away and isolate syllables. - The creep. Hester tastes the Tear's boundary grain and finds a gradient of "quickness" no deeper than a finger's width. Sorle, working through his drift, calculates the creep rate. The Ostrin near the boundary have lived about eleven minutes since 0 Y.E. For a Brinery sleeper, the same arithmetic gives perhaps a third of a second in thirteen years (provisional figure). Hester realises that Tib is, in a sense, still saying *let me sleep*. - The lexicon. Taevo arrives from the White with Ennor's whole song-cycle, Ennor having died that winter (provisional). Teo matches Wend syllables to Roar speech and builds a lexicon of forty words: *sea, fire, mother, ship, hold, keep, over*. - The Choir's own song. The Stay Choir's traditional wordless slow-song, sung for nine centuries, matches Ostrin keeping-chants. The founders stole the songs along with the craft. The Ostrin invented keeping, and the Marrane stole it. -

Translation. *Aelith?* means "Is it over?" (signature moment 20). The Ostrin believe the battle is still raging.

Act II — The Ethics Explode. - Publication. Teo publishes the lexicon through the Lodge presses at Quell. Vey would have suppressed it, and Teo goes over his head. - Riots. The Tiders riot, believing these are the judged souls of their prophecy. In Lowside a Tider mob smashes a lantern factor's. In the Mardens Tiders burn an Exchequer grain depot. - Suppression. The Exchequer closes presses and arrests preachers. Vey bans Sonance readings of Deep grain. Ferrers calls the voices "echoes, not persons." That position becomes the Charterist creed. - Hester's crisis. Her whole craft has been spending people. She stops working grain. She goes to the Cold House and sits beside Tib's casing for a night, considering releasing him. It would be her old wound inverted: letting him die to stop spending them. She does not, because the choice must be for him, as she promised in B1, and not to ease her own conscience. - Aldous. Dying of salt-lung, Aldous asks Hester to take him to the Cold House. He has visited every week since the Vigil of 903 (Book One, Ch. 26); this is his last visit (signature moment 19). He talks to the boy about landships, whistles badly, and tells Hester: "You kept him. I left him. Neither of us was right. Both of us loved him." He dies four days later. - Lovers. After the funeral at the Lowside Pans, Hester and Lucan become lovers. It is quiet, adult and unhurried: two people who have counted the cost of everything, deciding not to count this.

Act III — The Choir Project. - The proposal. Hester, Teo and Sorle propose to answer: to repurpose the Stay Choir to *sing* into the salt through the Founders' Shaft's live-brine column to the Hush boundary. - Orsolya's counsel. Orsolya is brought under guard from the cells to teach the Choir the boundary work only a Warden knows. She and Sorle sit side by side for the first time since 871. - The ethical knot. To be heard and to hear in reply, the boundary must be quickened slightly. Its Ostrin time must be let run nearer to Rim speed for the exchange. That means letting the battle proceed for seconds, during which someone may die. The choristers vote. They agree to the smallest vent the mathematics allows. - Vey forbids it. The Conclave reformers, led by Crisp (provisional: now Warden of the Upper Fathoms), outvote him and authorise the project. - Lucan's numbers. In parallel Lucan prepares an Exchequer-grade model to show that a halt is

survivable. It depends on a Rim-wide Restitution Fund (provisional), Quell glass credit, Harl grain and the end of Brinery fees for the poor. His father reads it and calls him a traitor to his name.

Act IV — Contact. - The vote is called. The Conclave schedules the deep-mining vote for the night after the Choir's attempt. Both sides believe contact will decide it. - The Choir descends. Three hundred choristers in the Choir chamber. Teo at the Founders' Shaft head in the Hush. Hester at the boundary with her hands in live brine. Orsolya and Sorle hold the Fifth Fathom's stays as a safety line.

Climax

The Choir sings into the salt (signature moment 21). - Teo leads the ancient chant with its words restored for the first time in nine hundred years. - Hester vents the boundary by the smallest pulse she has ever made. Her release, her weakness, is now her instrument. - Teo and Hester answer: Teo sings *Aelith?* back to them, the question returned as a sign of hearing, and adds the Ostrin word for *we hear*. - Silence. The pressure in the Hush rises, and the choristers begin to lag. - Then a reply comes up the brine column, in a woman's voice, at nearly human speed: a name. Vaimé. Teo knows the honorific in it from the lexicon: *keeper*. - The Choir comes out of the hold. Three choristers have drifted and will not fully return (provisional).

Resolution

[A]The next night the Conclave votes to halt deep mining, 34 to 26 (provisional). Vey is overruled in his own house.

[A]The Assize ratifies the halt under public pressure. The book's central conflict is decided: mining stops.

[A]The cost: the Exchequer's economy cracks. Grain prices triple. Brinery fees soar. Delvers are laid off by the thousand. Riots break out in Lowside and Ostmere. Ferrers announces the Exchequer will "not be bound by a vote of salt-mystics."

[A]Hester returns to grain-work. She will spend what she must to undo what was done. She signs the Cold House's petition for a halt that will put Tib on dwindling stock, knowing what it costs.

Character arcs

[A]Hester: her crisis is complicity. She passes through paralysis to responsibility: she will not stop working the salt, she will work it to pay it back. She chooses Lucan.

[A]Teo: he becomes the Listener. He is the first to translate Ostrin and the voice that answered.

[A]Saskia: she is Founding Inquiry secretary, and the book's realist. She warns that a halt without a plan for the Delvers will burn Lowside, and is right. She builds the Lowside–Delver relief compact (provisional) that holds in B5.

[A]Lucan: he becomes Hester's lover. His model proves a halt is survivable, and his father calls him a traitor.

[A]Aske: limping and delighted, he is Teo's assayer, dating each Roar fragment by depth. He teaches the Choir's young choristers left-handed brinescript.

[A]Sorle: he makes his last great calculation, the creep, while visibly Settling. He forgives Orsolya at the Choir: "You were right to demolish me. I was insufferable. I was also right."

[A]Orsolya: she teaches from her chains. Her hold at the climax is a rehearsal for her death.

[A]Aldous: he dies, after a last visit to Tib. His line becomes Hester's creed for B7.

[A]New: Taevo (provisional) grows into the Wend's interpreter. Reader Ilse Varro (provisional) is Teo's Sonance Reader and protector.

Key relationships

[A]Hester and Lucan: lovers, and partners from here.

[A]Hester and Aldous: reconciled at a casing, then grief.

[A]Teo and Vaimé: a relationship of one word, which will grow into a friendship across time.

[A]Sorle and Orsolya: enmity becomes colleagueship, and then something like love.

[A]Lucan and Aurel: fracture.

Magical discoveries

[A]The Ostrin language. A forty-word lexicon by the climax, and hundreds of words by the end of the book.

[A]The Ostrin invented keeping. The Choir's chants are theirs.

[A]The creep.

> Rule extension: kept minds are not absolutely still at a casing's boundary. Where the boundary has been thinned (by quickening, mining or venting), held time advances at a tiny rate proportional to the thinning. This is fixed in the architecture, and it needs a formal entry in MAGIC_SYSTEM.md.

[A]Speech across the boundary.

> Rule extension: sound carries through continuous live brine into the boundary of a held moment, and out of it, at a speed governed by the boundary's local time-rate. This is consistent with "still runs to quick" because it uses physical brine contact only, with no sympathetic link. Communication requires deliberately quickening the boundary, at a moral cost.

[A]Every keeping draws on the Ostrin moment. This is already canon in the Corollary's objective reason. It becomes public knowledge.

Political developments

[A]The deep-mining halt passes the Conclave and the Assize.

[A]Vey is humiliated but retains the Chancellorship.

[A]Ferrers declares the Exchequer's non-compliance. This is the road to war.

[A]The Delvers' Guild splits: one faction blames the Ostrin, the other the Exchequer.

[A]The Tiders are radicalised.

[A]Quell's presses become the Rim's free press.

[A]The Restitution Fund is proposed but not funded.

Mystery developments

[A]Book mystery: what are they saying? Solution: *Aelith?* means "Is it over?" They believe the battle still rages. A keeper named Vaimé answered.

[A]Saga mystery: why did the founders do it, and was it really mercy? The Ostrin are mid-*battle*, not mid-flood, so Holm's "to end a flood" is now visibly false. Saskia's Inquiry begins asking what battle, and against whom.

Major revelations, with supporting evidence

1. The Ostrin are alive and aware. B1: "Aelith," and Ch. 13's sleepers "breathing" as a deliberate echo. B3: the clear figure at the window. B4: the creep.
2. Keeping is Ostrin craft. World Bible: the Ostrin were "lost with the sea." B1: the motto's irony. B3: Ostrin syllables in the Wend chant. B4: the Choir's slow-song matches.
3. "Aelith?" means "Is it over?" B1: the rising, questioning intonation Teo noticed at the Vigil.
4. Tib's casing, and every keeping, feeds on their moment. MAGIC_SYSTEM's Corollary, that old keepings grow stiller by drawing on the deep grain's held moment.
5. Holm's flood story was a lie. The Ostrin speak of ships, fire and an enemy shore.

Series consequences

[A]Deep mining is halted by law and defied by the Exchequer.

[A]The economy is broken and the Delvers are idle.

[A]Vey and Ferrers are aligned, and Hask's medicine supply is threatened. The Hask mercenaries become available.

[A]Contact exists, but only through one name.

[A]Aldous is dead. Hester and Lucan are together. Sorle is failing. Orsolya is trusted, unofficially.

BOOK FIVE — THE RED GRAIN

906–907 Y.E. Conflict: civil conflict and war. Hester is 36–37.

Working title and one-line pitch

The Red Grain. The Rim goes to war over whether to keep spending a people, and Hester learns what she will do to save a child.

Premise

The halt has bankrupted the Exchequer. Brinery fees have doubled as Deep stock dwindles, and Lowside has no work. Hask, whose kingdom depends on kept medicine, has stopped receiving it.

Lord Exchequer Aurel Ferrers and Chancellor Vey's Charterists ally with Hask mercenaries under Marshal Radik Ostovar (provisional). Together they seize the Shelf and resume mining in the Hush.

To hold the city they use Sanguine Grain, the capital crime of 611. They make keyed keepings of hostages: the children and spouses of reformer Readers, Delver captains and Assize members. The casings open only for their Charterist keyers. They are displayed in the Quiet Rooms as "surety."

Themes

[A]Order versus justice. The Charterists offer order, a working economy, medicine for Hask and light for the rich. The rising offers justice and chaos.

[A]Who pays. Lowside always pays: in the coup, in the rising, in the fire.

Central conflict

Civil war on the Rim. The Exchequer–Charterist–Hask coalition holds the Halcyon and the mines. Against it stand the Lowside rising, the Delvers, the reformer Readers in exile, Quell and Harl.

Setting developments

[A]The Halcyon occupied. Mercenaries on the Stair. Hush galleries reopened by forced labour.

[A]Lowside barricaded, then half-burned.

[A]The Causeway as a front line.

[A]The Cistern, Bɪ's founders' tunnels, now an infiltration route.

[A]Ferrers House in the upper wards.

[A]Tidewater Abbey at Harl, the site of the treaty.

[A]The Quiet Rooms as a hostage gallery.

Act-by-act outline

Act I — The Coup. - The Lantern Hour. As the kept noon light fills the refectory, Hask companies cross the Causeway. Excisemen seize the Exchequer's own Assize members. The Proctors split; Gage refuses Vey's order to arrest the Conclave reformers and is himself arrested. - The Readers. Crisp is kept in a keyed casing (provisional). The remaining reformers are confined to the Readers' Close. Sorle is too frail to move and refuses to leave anyway. - Escape. Hester and Teo escape through the Cistern, Bɪ's route reversed, and come up under the Cold House beside Tib. - Pip is taken. Pip, now nine, is taken from her Glassmarket school and kept in a keyed casing. Saskia is away at Quell on Inquiry business when it happens. - Vey's proclamation. The Ostrin are "echoes, not persons." Mining resumes, and the Hush is reopened by delvers working at musket-point. - Orsolya released into service (fixed truth; this interpretation is provisional). Vey has no Warden who can hold the Stays against the quickenings that forced mining will cause, so he frees Orsolya from the cells to do it. She accepts. Hester,

hearing of it, believes Orsolya has turned again. - Lucan inside. He stays in Ferrers House, apparently loyal, passing his father's dispositions out through Daisy Fenn's customs couriers.

Act II — The Lowside Rising. - The Delvers. The Hask companies drive delvers into a quickening gallery, and nine die. The Delvers' Guild, split since B4, reunites and rises. Lowside throws up barricades from the Pans to Coldwater Street. - Hester as a political figure. She speaks from her father's brine-pans to ten thousand people. She is no orator: she lists the weights. What was taken, from whom, at what rate. It works because it is true. - The alliance. With Saskia, she brokers an alliance of Lowside, the Delvers, the Tiders, Quell (Dagny Strand's landships and Lodge glassmen) and Harl (Teo's family sends grain wagons). - Lucan's public break. At an emergency session of the rump Assize in Lowside, Lucan reads aloud his father's written order for the keyed hostages, with Aurel's signature and seal. He renounces his place in the Ferrers succession (provisional) and asks to be tried with the rest if the rising fails. - The fire. Ferrers retaliates by burning Lowside's western streets. Mercenaries fire the brine-sheds, and the wind does the rest. Lowside is half-burned. Aldous's pans are lost.

Act III — The Siege. - The lines. The rising besieges the Shelf. The Causeway is held by Delver militia. Strand's landships patrol the White flank, so the Charterists cannot export the grain they are mining. - Inside the Halcyon. Orsolya and Sorle are working together, not apart. Forced mining in the Hush is driving the quickenings toward catastrophe, and Orsolya holds the Stays with a conscripted Choir. In secret she is slowing the cutting, sabotaging rods and misreporting yields. She was never Vey's. - The infiltration. Hester goes back in through the Cistern to the Old Tap with Teo and Gage, whom the rising freed from a Proctory transport. - Learning the forbidden craft. Gage has brought the Mattias Horne case files from the Proctory archive: the only written account of keying. Hester learns Sanguine Grain from a murderer's notes. - Pip freed (signature moment 24). In the Quiet Rooms Hester captures Pip's keyer, a Charterist Reader, Silas Merrow (provisional). He will not open the casing. She takes his blood by force, salts it, works it into her own hands and releases Pip, who is terrified and alive. Hester has committed a capital crime and a violation of a man's body. She does not regret it, and that frightens her more than the act. - The

other hostages. She frees eleven more the same way before Merrow's blood runs out. Four casings keyed to other keyers remain sealed. - Sorle's last lecture (signature moment 22). The quickening breaks in the Fifth Fathom. Sorle, unable to walk, has himself carried to the Choir. He gives the conscripted choristers his last lecture: the arrears calculus of the Great Keeping, and what they are really holding. He asks them to hold not for the Exchequer but for the people under the salt, until the mining stops. Then he holds with them. He dies Settled at the lectern, mid-sentence. Orsolya finishes the sentence. The Choir does not break, and the mercenaries in the Hush flee the quickening. The forced mining stops.

Act IV — The Journal. - The strongroom. In Ferrers House, Lucan opens his father's strongroom. Ferrers has left the house for the Shelf. Lucan finds Ysolde's full journal, held by the Ferrers line since the Exchequer's founding in 212 as a surety between the Seal and the Exchequer (provisional). The Ferrers have always known. - The truth. The founders knowingly kept 200,000 people to annihilate the Ilisse fleet. They were losing a twenty-year war, and the Keeping won it. Ysolde's last line (signature moment 23): *"We will tell them it was the sea's doing. God forgive us, we will believe it ourselves."* - Publication. Lucan carries the journal to the Lowside presses. It is printed in a night and read aloud on the barricades and, crucially, to the Hask companies. Corrant Hask, the Quiet Company's co-leader, is the namesake hero of the Haskish crown. Ostovar's captains learn their contract is defending the heirs of a massacre that bears their kingdom's founder's name. Unpaid as well, two Hask companies stand down.

Climax

The Battle of the Causeway. - With the Halcyon untenable, Vey and Ferrers attempt a breakout across the Causeway to the Dry Harbour. They are escorting a train of cut Hush grain, the coup's whole yield, to Ferrers landships. - The Delver militia, Lodge landships and Lowside companies meet them on the two-mile road under the kept-light posts. - Hester holds the Causeway's central span: she keeps a breaching wagon's charge mid-blast in a brine-drenched culvert, and lags. - Teo and Saskia lead the Lowside line. - Gage, Chief Proctor again by acclamation, arrests Chancellor Vey on the Causeway, by the Charter he served. Vey surrenders politely. - Ferrers flees by landship across the White toward Hask.

Half the Hush grain train escapes with him (provisional quantity: about a tenth of all Hush grain ever cut).

Resolution

[A]The Rim Concord Treaty of Harl, signed at Tidewater Abbey by Ambry, Quell, Harl and Ostmere. Hask is excluded pending reparations.

[A]The treaty ends the war and establishes the Commission of Return: a Concord body charged with planning the restitution of the sea and its people. The Conclave, purged, votes to give the Commission authority over the Halcyon's lower Fathoms.

[A]Vey is held for trial. The remaining keyed hostages are released when Merrow and two other keyers surrender and open their casings under amnesty. Crisp lives.

[A]Hester confesses her sanguine work before the Proctory. She is pardoned under the treaty, but the record stands.

[A]Lowside is half-burned.

[A]The war is over and won. The Rim has decided to give the sea back.

Character arcs

[A]Hester: she becomes a political figure, a voice of Lowside on the Commission. Her moral stain, freeing Pip with forbidden grain, is a permanent mark, and it means she will never again think herself simply good. She loses Sorle.

[A]Teo: he leads Lowside militia, hating it, and keeps the Listener's work alive in a burning city. He talks to Vaimé's boundary twice in secret, and Vaimé's replies grow longer.

[A]Saskia: Pip is taken and freed. Her rage turns into command: she runs the rising's supply and becomes its de facto quartermaster-general. At Harl she wins the Commission's charter clauses.

[A]Lucan: he breaks with his father publicly, finds and publishes the journal, and loses his inheritance. He gains his name.

[A]Aske: he runs the rising's assay. He checks grain for sabotage, authenticates the journal by cold-dating its salt to 0–3 Y.E., and keeps everyone fed on shellfish paste and jokes.

[A]Sorle: he dies Settled in the Choir, giving his last lecture. His chalk-name is the first written on the Stair after the war.

[A]Orsolya: released into service, she is the inside saboteur. She finishes Sorle's sentence. The treaty commutes her sentence to service under the Commission.

[A]New: Marshal Radik Ostovar (provisional), Silas Merrow (provisional).

Key relationships

[A]Hester and Saskia: the debt of Pip, which Saskia insists is not a debt.

[A]Lucan and Aurel: severance.

[A]Sorle and Orsolya: they finish each other's work.

[A]Hester and Orsolya: trust restored in the dark of the Fifth Fathom.

[A]Hester and Lucan: tested by separation and by his father. They hold.

Magical discoveries

[A]Sanguine Grain in practice: keyed casings, their making and their breaking.

> Rule extension: a keyed casing releases to any worker who carries the keyer's own blood- or tear-salt worked into live brine on their hands. It "opens only for them" in the sense that only their body-salt unlocks it. The rule needs a formal statement, because Hester's act depends on it.

[A]The Great Keeping's mechanics. From Ysolde's journal: three thousand workers in a synchronised hold, the Ostrin chant stolen and turned, and the Hush as the founders' working floor, *still active*. That is why the Hush hums.

[A]Forced mining's consequence. Cutting the Hush drives quickenings toward catastrophe. Bi's Fathoming, at war scale.

Political developments

[A]The Exchequer coup, the Lowside rising and the Battle of the Causeway.

[A]The Treaty of Harl and the Commission of Return.

[A]Vey arrested. Ferrers in exile with a fortune in Hush grain. Hask disgraced and divided.

[A]The Delvers reunited.

[A]Lowside's political power is born: Hester, Saskia and the Guild.

[A]The Halcyon's Charter is suspended under Commission authority.

Mystery developments

[A]Book mystery: where is the founders' full account, and who has kept it? Solution: the Ferrers strongroom. The Exchequer has been the Seal's silent partner since 212.

[A]Saga mystery: why the Ebb was made. Solution: to win a war by keeping an enemy people. The founders' lie included lying to themselves.

Major revelations, with supporting evidence

1. The founders' deliberate keeping of 200,000 Ostrin to annihilate the fleet. B2: "the only mercy left us"; Holm's implausible flood. B3: the tower's alarm-bells. B4: the Ostrin speak of ships, fire and an enemy shore. World Bible: the twenty-year war.
2. The Ferrers line held the journal. B1: the Ferrers firm's ease with forbidden grain. B2: the Exchequer's founding in 212 shortly before the 230 Fire; Aurel's distance from Rade. B3: the Exchequer's 812 suppression. B4: Aurel's "echoes" creed.
3. Orsolya was never Vey's. B1: she chose rightly at the vent. B4: her teaching at the Choir. B5: the misreported yields Aske notices in the coup's grain.
4. Corrant Hask is the namesake of the Haskish crown. World Bible: the Quiet Company's co-leader.

Series consequences

- [A]The Commission of Return exists, and the decision to return the sea is made.
- [A]Ferrers is free in Hask with a hoard of Hush grain. That is the seed of B7's Second Keeping.
- [A]Lowside is half-burned and must be rebuilt, and will have to be evacuated because it sits on the old seabed.
- [A]Sorle is dead. His arrears calculus passes to Hester and Lucan.
- [A]Hester carries the sanguine knowledge and the stain.

BOOK SIX — THE EBB REVERSED

907–908 Y.E. Conflict: engineering catastrophe and recovery. Hester is 37–38.

Working title and one-line pitch

The Ebb Reversed. Undoing a nine-hundred-year wrong turns out to be an engineering problem, a refugee crisis and a test of whether two peoples can survive each other.

Premise

Returning the sea all at once would drown every Rim city built on the old seabed. Its arrears, nine centuries of a living sea's pressure, would be catastrophic.

The Commission plans the Great Vent, a staged return over years through a Ring of shafts around the Hollow's margins (provisional: twelve shafts). The lower cities are evacuated ahead of the water. Hester is chief engineer of the western arc.

The first returns happen at the margins. The Ostrin who come back arrive mid-battle and terrified: to them, the war began eleven minutes ago.

Themes

- [A] Repair is harder than harm. The Keeping took one night. The return takes years.
- [A] Living with the wronged. Restitution means sharing a city with people who have every reason to hate you.

Central conflict

- [A] Sabotage by remnant Charterists, funded from Hask by Ferrers and run by Fennick Rade (B2, provisional).
- [A] Rim fear of the Ostrin, which the saboteurs feed. Every Ostrin act of violence becomes a pamphlet.

The Vent must be built, held and trusted, all at once.

Setting developments

- [A] The Ring: shaft-heads and vent-gates around the Hollow. The Gate of Coldbank sits on the old Coldbank workings south of Lowside, where Orsolya's father died in 856.
- [A] Lowside evacuated. Its people move to upslope camps, and the Cold House sleepers are carried uphill in their casings.
- [A] The Harl Compound (provisional): the Commission's camp for returned Ostrin.
- [A] The rising margins: brackish shallows creeping over the White, with returned weed, fish and shellfish.
- [A] Ilisse's outer barges: the first Ostrin ships to surface.

Act-by-act outline

Act I — Engineering and Evacuation. - The Vent designed. Hester and Lucan finish Sorle's calculus. She supplies the weights, he supplies the rhythm of the staged pulses. The first Commission head, Commissioner Edric Tull (provisional), is a Concord appointee who prefers schedules to people. - The evacuation.

Lowside is the first district to go: the burned streets and the unburned. Hester walks her own street with the evacuation clerks and fails to persuade her neighbours until Daisy Fenn does it with gossip and bread. - Moving Tib. The Cold House sleepers are carried upslope casing by casing. Mother Agathe names each one aloud as it goes. Tib's casing cracks on a cart in the frost. Hester recasts it on the road with her bare hands. - The first shaft. It opens at the southern margin, near Harl. Water rises: the first planned return. - Sabotage begins. Pamphlets ("The Drowned Are Coming"), Commission surveyors beaten, a sabotaged lift at the Ostmere shaft (provisional).

Act II — Thaelin. - The first returned (signature moment *25*). A girl in salt-stained armour, holding a short sword, stands up in the shallows of the southern vent and sees a red desert, the Scald's edge, where a moment ago there was an enemy shore. Thaelin (fifteen, a marine of the Ilisse fleet) kills a Commission worker who reaches for her. - "Aelith?" Teo wades in alone and unarmed. She asks it, and he answers in her own language: *it is over. It has passed. It was nine hundred years ago.* She does not believe him for eleven days. - Fear. More returns: forty, then three hundred, sailors and marines from the outer barges. Some fight, and two Rim villages are raided. The Commission confines the returned to the Harl Compound, which is uncomfortably like a prison. Rade's pamphlets call for the Vent to be stopped. The Assize wavers. - Hester's failure (signature moment *27*). Her western-arc vent at the Ambry margin opens on schedule. She has calculated the arrears of that section of the moment as water. But the section holds part of the Ilisse fleet's rearguard, hundreds of living people and ships, and Law 4 is merciless: living things accrue arrears far faster than water. The vent overruns. A surge floods lower Ambry: Lowside, the Pans and the old Dry Harbour quays. Most residents are gone, but some stayed (provisional: thirty-eight dead). - Teo's stay. Teo holds a stay at the breach for six hours to buy evacuation time. He is heavily Settled: white-haired at thirty, his left side slow, his heart permanently slowed. He survives. - Hester resigns. Tull resigns too, and the Concord appoints Saskia head of the Commission.

Act III — Ostrin Keeper-craft. - The miscount. Hester, disgraced, goes to the Harl Compound to ask Thaelin why the rearguard was where she didn't expect it. She has realised that the Ostrin could have told her the fleet's disposition if

anyone had asked. The answer: the rearguard had turned back to protect the keeper-barge. - Vaimé returned. The keeper-barge was moored at the Marrane shore, beside the founders' station at what is now the Shelf. Vaimé, its keeper-priestess, was attempting a counter-keeping against the Quiet Company when the moment closed over her. That is why her voice reached the Founders' Shaft in B4. Saskia authorises a dedicated return of the barge through the Founders' Shaft. Vaimé comes up the shaft Hester vented in B1, into the Hush and the presence of the craft's thieves. - The alliance. Vaimé knows Teo's voice. She is grief-struck, imperious, practical and curious. She and Saskia negotiate: Ostrin keepers will work the Vent alongside Rim workers. In exchange the Commission frees the Compound and grants the returned the legal standing of Concord residents (provisional). - The gentling. The Ostrin have always vented. Their release-craft, *the gentling* (provisional term), is what Hester reinvented from her father's pans. They count the arrears of living keepings by listening to them. Teo, half-Settled, becomes the essential interpreter. - Ostrin medicine. Vaimé visits the upslope Cold House camp and sees the charity sleepers' grey bloom pallor. She names it: *sea-cough*, a disease Ilisse knew well. Its cure, a physic-compound prepared and kept in the physic-houses of Ilisse (provisional name: *brine-wort draught*), lies in the moment's heart. It is not magic, only medicine that has been kept. Hester stands at Tib's casing and allows herself to hope out loud.

Act IV — Sabotage. - The plan. Rade's cell, funded by Ferrers, prepares to break the Gate of Coldbank, the western arc's master gate. If it fails, the whole western moment surges at once and drowns what is left of lower Ambry and the Halcyon's Fathoms. - The night. On the night of the Vent's largest planned pulse, the cell destroys the gate's brass regulators and the brine-lift counterweights. The gate begins to fail.

Climax

The Gate of Coldbank holds through Orsolya's last hold (signature moment 26). - Orsolya, now Commission Fathomer, is sixty-two and white to the bone. She puts her hands in the gate's brine and holds the failing gate alone while the crews rebuild the regulators around her. It is the hold she has trained for all her life, at the place where her father died. - Hester and Vaimé work the release side,

gentling the surge into the shaft in measured pulses. Hester is the Rim's best keeper and worst releaser; Vaimé is the Ostrin's best releaser. Together they are a complete craft. - Teo interprets between the two teams. - Thaelin and a crew of returned Ostrin marines haul regulator plates alongside Delvers. - Lucan counts the pulse. - The regulators are rebuilt and the gate holds. - Orsolya does not let go. Her final Settle is a chosen, completed hold. Her last words, to Hester: "Hold the line so the others can sleep, chick. Then wake them."

Resolution

[A]Ostrin and Rim workers together stabilise the Vent. The western arc completes its stage, and the margins are returned around the whole Ring.

[A]Rade and his cell are taken. Their confessions document Ferrers's funding and his purchase of grain across the Rim. He is building something.

[A]Hester is reinstated as chief engineer by Saskia, publicly, with the Coldbank crews' petition.

[A]Orsolya's chalk-name is written on the Stair beside Sorle's.

[A]The book's conflict is resolved: the sabotage is defeated and Rim–Ostrin cooperation is proven in the worst night of the Vent. The final Return is now possible.

Character arcs

[A]Hester: she fails publicly. Her vent floods lower Ambry because she counted the sea as water and not as people. She recovers by listening, the lesson Teo learned in B1, and by partnering with Vaimé. She learns that repair means asking the wronged.

[A]Teo: heavily Settled holding a stay, he survives. His body is slower and his voice is the most important on the Rim. He and Mattie marry (provisional) in the upslope camp.

[A]Saskia: she becomes the Commission's head. She is merciless with schedules and generous with people, the first Rim leader the Ostrin trust.

[A]Lucan: the Vent's rhythm-master. A Concord envoy in training, he begins negotiating with Hask over Ferrers's extradition.

[A]Aske: he assays the returned margins and finds the old Ostrine oyster beds alive in the shallows. He spends his free hours ankle-deep in them. "They are *magnificent*. They are entirely *wrong*. They are delicious."

[A]Orsolya: she dies holding the Great Vent's failing gate. It is her redemption completed: a hold that keeps the living, ended by choice.

[A]New major characters:

Thaelin: fierce, grieving, funny in two languages. Her family is in Ilisse.

Vaimé: a keeper-priestess of Ilisse. Proud, precise and wounded. She is Hester's Ostrin counterpart and the future Speaker.

Key relationships

[A]Hester and Vaimé: suspicion, then a partnership of opposite skills.

[A]Teo and Thaelin: the first friendship across the gap.

[A]Hester and Orsolya: completed.

[A]Saskia and Vaimé: two hard negotiators who respect each other at once.

[A]Lucan and Hester: a partnership tested by public disgrace, in which he is the steadier one for once.

Magical discoveries

[A]Ostrin keeper-craft: the gentling. It is venting as an ancient, refined art, with arrears read by song.

[A]Ostrin medicine: the bloom fever is *sea-cough*, and its cure exists in the kept physic-houses of Ilisse. This obeys the hard limit: no healing by magic. The cure is a medicine, merely kept.

[A]The arrears of the living at basin scale. Hester's error confirms Law 4 brutally.

[A]Margin return mechanics: water, weed, fish, shellfish and people resuming from the moment, mid-motion.

Political developments

[A]The Commission takes on administration as well as engineering.

[A]Returned Ostrin gain Concord residency.

[A]The Assize nearly halts the Vent, and the Coldbank night ends the vote.

[A]Hask's internal crisis deepens over Ferrers.

[A]Rim cities begin planning permanent upslope rebuilding.

[A]The Halcyon's lower Fathoms are formally ceded to the Commission.

Mystery developments

[A]Book mystery: who is sabotaging the Vent, and why does the western arc behave wrongly? Solution: Rade's cell, funded by Ferrers, for the sabotage. The rearguard protecting Vaimé's barge, for Hester's miscount.

[A]Saga mystery: what cure exists for Tib? *Sea-cough* physic, kept in Ilisse. And what is Ferrers building with the world's grain?

Major revelations, with supporting evidence

1. The bloom fever is an Ostrin-known disease, and its cure lies in Ilisse. B1: Agathe's "older than the Ebb" (Ch. 1 or 18). World Bible: the Great Bloom of 788. Revelation Ledger: Tib's cure.
2. Vaimé was at the founders' station, mid-counter-keeping. B1: the Hush hums because the working is still active. B4: her reply came up the Founders' Shaft at near-human speed, because her boundary sits closest to the founders' working.
3. Venting was always Ostrin craft. B4: the Choir's chants were stolen. B6: the gentling.
4. Ferrers is buying the world's grain. B5: the escaped Hush train. B6: Rade's confession.

Series consequences

[A]The final Return of Ilisse itself is now possible.

[A]The cure for Tib is real, and it lies in the moment's heart.

[A]Orsolya is dead. Teo is Settled. Vaimé and Thaelin are allies.

[A]Ferrers is preparing something with a vast reserve of grain.

[A]Brinery keepings across the Rim have begun to weep as the moment thins.

BOOK SEVEN — WHEN THE SEA REMEMBERS

908–909 Y.E. Conflict: restitution and reckoning. Hester is 38–39.

Working title and one-line pitch

When the Sea Remembers. The world must give back the sea and every keeping it ever made, and Hester must let go of the last stillness on earth to bring her brother home.

Premise

The final Return will be Ilisse itself: the heart of the moment, and the 200,000 people still inside it.

As the moment is spent, stillsalt across the Rim weakens. The Commission's Horologists calculate that every keeping in the world will fail within a year. Every family with a sleeper must choose: - return them now, to die or recover as they would have; - wait for Ostrin cures, which exist for some illnesses (sea-cough and a few fevers) but not for most; - let go.

Meanwhile, in Hask, Aurel Ferrers has bought or stolen almost every ounce of grain left on the Rim. He means to use it for a Second Keeping. As Ilisse's heart resumes, his hired Choir will re-keep it, making a new held moment: a fresh deep of stillsalt for another nine hundred years, owned by him.

Themes

[A]Letting go. It is Hester's weakness, and the saga's answer.

[A]What is kept can be returned. The motto *What is kept is not lost* is redeemed: it was true, and it was owed.

Central conflict

The last Charterist against the Return. Ferrers attempts a Second Keeping. Once he falls, his vast reserve of grain is in Hester's hands. Kept, it would hold every Brinery sleeper on the Rim for a century, Tib's among them, cure or no cure.

Hester must choose to release it all.

Setting developments

[A]The Brineries' great choice. The Cold House, private brineries and the Halcyon's Quiet Rooms.

[A]The Deep opened: the Bell Shaft (provisional), sunk beside the tower of Ilisse.

[A]Ilisse's physic-house, inside a partly returned pocket of the moment.

[A]The returning sea over a season: the Rim's old shoreline reborn, and Ambry's lower wards under water by consent.

[A]The Halcyon refounded, its lower Fathoms flooded and its Crown a sea-university.

[A]Ferrers's working at the Deep's eastern edge, landed from Hask.

Act-by-act outline

Act I — The Keepings Weaken. - The proclamation. Saskia announces the Commission's finding: within a year no keeping will hold. - Ambry first. Ambry's Cistern-linked brineries weep first. Still runs to quick through the founders' lines into the quickening Hush, exactly the draw of B1 run by the sea itself. - The Brineries' choice (signature moment 28). The Cold House holds a public day of returns. Mother Agathe, seventy-five, names each sleeper as their family brings them back. Some wake and die within hours. Some recover. Some families choose to wait for Ostrin cures. Across the Rim, cities make the same choice, ward by ward. - Tib. Hester decides for him, not for herself. Tib wanted to be a pilot. With a cure, he would want to live. She will wait, which means the

cure must be fetched before his casing fails. - Vey's last gift. Vey, Settled and awaiting trial, sends for Hester. He gives her the Seal's last secret: the founders' working in the Hush is still active and must be released for Ilisse's heart to return. He also tells her that Ferrers knows this, and intends to stand where Ysolde stood. Vey asks nothing in return. "I kept a secret for thirty years because I was afraid of what it would cost to stop. I find that it costs very little now."

Act II — The Descent. - The party. Hester descends the Bell Shaft into the Deep with Vaimé, Thaelin, Teo (half-Settled, as Listener), Lucan and Aske, who insisted. "I have been under salt once. I am the only qualified person." - The lock. Using Ostrin gentling, they vent a lock, a pocket of returned moment, around Ilisse's main physic-house. For the first time, Rim people walk in Ilisse. Bells ring three-and-one: the alarm Lucan counted in B3. Ostrin physicians stand mid-evacuation, still as statues, while their nearest neighbours wake and stare. - The cure. A returned Ostrin physician, Saelor (provisional), gives his consent, and with it the kept sea-cough cure and its preparation. The deal is fair and explicit: the Rim gives back the sea, and Ilisse gives back a cure. - The birds. Above the physic-house, in the held air above the drowned harbour, Hester sees halcyon birds, kept mid-flight above the waves: the emblem's truth. - The cost. The ascent is a long rush. Hester's heart nearly overdrives.

Act III — The Return of Ilisse. - The working released. The Commission begins the final Return over a single season. Hester and Vaimé release the founders' working in the Hush, the hum falling silent for the first time in nine hundred years. - Teo speaks the Return. In the Choir, by the Founders' Shaft and down every shaft of the Ring, Teo speaks to 200,000 waking minds. He answers the saga's first question: *"Aelith. It is over. It has passed. You have been kept nine hundred years, and we have come to give you back."* The Ilisse fleet stands down by its own command, at Vaimé's word. Some fighting breaks out at the eastern harbour. Thaelin finds her mother. - The Second Keeping. Ferrers's Choir begins on the eastern edge: three hundred hired keepers fed by his hoard. As Ilisse's eastern quarter returns, his working catches it and begins to re-still it, a new white sheet closing over people who woke minutes ago. - Father and son. Lucan crosses the salt to his father and does not persuade him. Aurel's argument is the Halcyon's motto, perfectly sincere: *what is kept is not lost.* - Ferrers falls. The

Hask choristers, unpaid and terrified, begin to drift. Ferrers takes the hold himself and is caught in his own working, kept, like Aske, by his own grain. His working fails without him, and the eastern quarter resumes.

Climax

The release of the reserve. - With Ferrers kept, his reserve lies on the salt: the last great body of stillsalt in the world. It has passed by law to the Commission, and in practice to Hester, the only worker on site strong enough to hold or release it. - The Brineries' Guild, Hask's envoys and hundreds of families with sleepers beg her by every means to keep it. A century more for every sleeper. A century more for Tib, cure or no cure. - Saskia, as Commission head, gives Hester the authority and does not instruct her. - The reserve is still part of the moment. If it is held, the eastern quarter of Ilisse can never fully resume, and its arrears will stay locked in a final pocket under the returning water. - Hester puts her hands in the brine. For the last time in the saga, she does the thing she is worst at. She lets go of all of it. The rush nearly stops her heart, and Vaimé and Lucan bring her back. - The reserve becomes sea. The last of Ilisse comes home. - Afterwards Hester vents Ferrers out of his own keeping, slowly, over days, so that he can stand trial. She returns even him.

Resolution

[A]The sea returns to the Hollow over a season. Ambry's lower wards lie under the new shallows. The Tear is now a bay.

[A]The halcyon birds fly from the returning water: blue, quick and real, nesting on the waves.

[A]The Halcyon is refounded as a sea-university. Its lower Fathoms are flooded by Conclave consent, and the chalk-names on the Stair go under the water deliberately, rechalked on the new seawall. Saskia is elected Chancellor.

[A]Magic dims. By the next winter, stillsalt keeps no longer. Only the memory of the art remains, in records, songs and the Settled bodies of its workers.

[A]Tib (signature moment 29). Tib is returned over three days in warm brine, with Ostrin physic and Saelor's draught. He wakes cured, sees his sister and says, "Hes? Why are you old?" She tells him the truth, as she promised: seventeen years; their father dead, having visited him at the end; a sea.

[A]Final outcomes:

Hester: a Reader of the new Halcyon, sea-side, and partner to Lucan.

Tib: a pilot.

Teo: Listener and interpreter, living with partial Settle.

Saskia: Chancellor.

Lucan: Rim Concord delegate.

Aske: a grower of oysters, happily.

Vaimé: Ostrin Speaker.

[A]Final image: Hester and Tib on the deck of a boat on a real sea. Tib is at the tiller, whistling.

Character arcs

[A]Hester: her completion. She moves from keeping as control (B1) to letting go as love. She returns Tib with the Ostrin cure, knowing he will wake into loss, and tells him the truth. She releases the world's last stillness.

[A]Teo: he speaks the Return, answering *Aelith* nine hundred years late. He is the Listener and interpreter between peoples. His body is slow and his life is full; he marries Mattie (if not already in B6).

[A]Saskia: she leads the Commission through the Return and is then elected Chancellor of the refounded Halcyon. Pip, now twelve, is a glazier's apprentice in a world without kept light.

[A]Lucan: he confronts his father and does not save him. He watches Hester save him instead. He becomes Rim Concord delegate, negotiating Ilisse's place in the Concord.

[A]Aske: he descends to Ilisse, comes home and plants the old Ostrine oyster strains in the new bay off the Shelf. He is happy.

[A]Tib: he wakes at fourteen into a world seventeen years older. He grieves his father, learns to sail on water rather than salt, and becomes a pilot. He befriends Thaelin, a fellow child of an interrupted moment.

[A]Vaimé: the woman who resisted the Keeping presides over its undoing. She becomes Ostrin Speaker.

[A]Thaelin: she reunites with her family and becomes an Ostrin envoy to the Rim (provisional).

[A]Aurel Ferrers: kept by his own hand, returned by Hester's, tried by the Concord (provisional: exiled to Hask for life).

[A]Vey: he dies Settled in custody, having told the truth once (provisional).

Key relationships

[A]Hester and Tib: the saga's first relationship completed. It was one-sided for seventeen years and becomes mutual on the last page.

[A]Hester and Lucan: partners.

[A]Hester and Vaimé: two keepers who chose release.

[A]Teo and Vaimé: the two voices of the Return.

[A]Lucan and Aurel: a son who no longer needs his father to change.

Magical discoveries

[A]The founders' working in the Hush is the active hold that sustains the Great Keeping. Its release ends the hum. (Revealed by Vey; implied in canon by "the Founders' working is still active.")

[A]Halcyon birds are kept in the moment.

[A]The weakening of keepings.

Rule extension: two mechanisms, both rule-compliant, must be stated in canon.

1. Keepings joined by continuous brine (Ambry's Cistern-linked brineries) lose stillness directly toward the quickening Hush under "still runs to quick."
2. All other keepings fail because no fresh grain exists to recast them, and natural weeping proceeds unopposed.

No sympathetic or non-local link is introduced. Writers must not suggest that distant grain "feels" the Return.

[A]Magic dims. Once the moment is wholly returned, no stillsalt remains in the basin.

Rule extension: surviving dry grain in stores loses its stillness within months of the Return (provisional rate). This must be grounded in an amendment, for example that cut grain's stillness is sustained by saturation from the parent moment through the founders' working, and ends when that working ends. The amendment must be worded so as not to contradict §2.5.

[A]The Second Keeping. A re-keeping of returning water is possible in principle (Law 1, at monstrous cost), which is why Ferrers is dangerous. It fails because no hired Choir can survive the hold.

Political developments

[A]Ilisse returns as a living polity. Vaimé is its Speaker, and it is admitted to the Rim Concord (provisional).

[A]The Exchequer is dissolved and reconstituted as a Concord Harbour Board (provisional).

[A]The Charter of the Grain lapses, there being no grain.

[A]The Halcyon is refounded. Ambry rebuilds upslope, and Lowside becomes a harbour ward.

[A]Hask extradites Ferrers in exchange for Ostrin medicine.

[A]The Tiders see their prophecy fulfilled and are bewildered by it.

[A]The Wend, under Taevo, are recognised as the people who kept the Ostrin language alive.

Mystery developments

[A]Book mystery: what is Ferrers building, and how can the heart of the moment be released? Solution: the Second Keeping, and the founders' working in the Hush, which Vey's secret explains and Hester and Vaimé undo.

[A]Saga mystery answered in full. What is the Hollow Sea? A kept sea with a people in it. What do we owe what we have kept? Its return.

Major revelations, with supporting evidence

1. The halcyon birds are kept in the moment. B1: the emblem; the "extinct" bird; the legend that the halcyon stilled the sea while it brooded.
2. The founders' working is still active. B1: the hum of the Hush. B5: Ysolde's journal on the Hush as the working floor. B7: Vey.
3. Ferrers intends a Second Keeping. B5: the escaped Hush train. B6: Rade's confession about grain purchases. B7: Vey's warning.
4. The motto was true. *What is kept is not lost*. Every book's evidence: Aske, the gull, Thaelin, Vaimé, Tib.

Series consequences

[A]The saga ends. The sea is home, the two peoples are reunited, and grainwork is a memory.

[A]Hester's brother is awake. Its last sound is a boy whistling on the water.

Saga continuity requirements

[A]☐

The fixed saga truth holds in every book. The sea was kept, with 200,000 Ostrin inside it, by the Halcyon's founders, to win a war. All grain-work spends that held moment.

A☐

The revelation order is never broken:

the Seal and the Ebb made (B2);

the city under the Deep (B3);

the Ostrin alive and aware, keeping as Ostrin craft (B4);

deliberate genocide, from Ysolde's full journal (B5);

the bloom cure in Ilisse (B6);

the halcyon birds kept (B7).

A☐

Holm's "to end a flood" stays a lie. It is exposed by B4–B5 evidence and never retconned into truth.

A☐

Ysolde's two fixed lines are quoted verbatim: "the Keeping was the only mercy left us" (B2); "We will tell them it was the sea's doing. God forgive us, we will believe it ourselves." (B5).

A☐

"Aelith?" means "Is it over?" / "Has it passed?" It is first heard in B1, translated in B4 and answered by Teo in B6 (to Thaelin) and B7 (to Ilisse).

A☐

Deaths happen in the fixed book and manner:

Holm: B2, after her confession.

Aldous: B4, of salt-lung, after visiting Tib.

Sorle: B5, Settled, giving his last lecture in the Choir.

Orsolya: B6, holding the Gate of Coldbank; a chosen, completed hold.

A☐

Final outcomes are exact:

Hester: Reader of the new Halcyon, partner to Lucan.

Tib: pilot.

Teo: Listener and interpreter, partially Settled.

Saskia: Chancellor.

Lucan: Rim Concord delegate.

Aske: oyster-grower, happily.

Vaimé: Ostrin Speaker.

A☐

Tib's arithmetic: kept 892 at 14; returned 909 at 14, cured, into a world 17 years older. Hester is 39. His first line is "Hes? Why are you old?"

A☐

Hester and Lucan: romance begins in B3, lovers from B4, partners thereafter. No breakup.

A☐

Aske carries his B1 cost (a stiff right hand, partial Settle) in every book. His B3 hip wound (provisional) is also permanent.

A☐

Teo is heavily Settled in B6 and never recovers. Magic dimming in B7 does not cure the Settle.

A☐

Vey's arc: Chancellor by vote at the end of B2; overruled in B4; arrested on the Causeway in B5. Ferrers flees in B5 and falls in B7.

A☐

Orsolya's status: imprisoned (B1–B4), released into service (B5), commuted to Commission service, dead (B6). Her hand is a widdershins spiral; she calls people "chick."

A☐

Hester's moral stain is permanent. She freed Pip by Sanguine Grain in B5 and must never be written as having been "cleansed" of it.

A☐

Still runs to quick through continuous live brine only, in every book. No sympathetic links, including in B7's weakening of keepings.

A☐

No healing by magic. The Ostrin sea-cough cure is a kept medicine.

A☐

Lag must be shown after every major hold. In particular: the burning beam (B2), the landship (B3, about an hour), the Choir contact (B4), the Causeway (B5), the release of the reserve (B7, the rush).

A☐

Every rule extension flagged here is ratified in DECISIONS.md before drafting. The extensions are: 0 Y.E. dating, landship scale, boundary creep, boundary speech, sanguine key-transfer, weakening of keepings, post-Return grain-fade.

A■

Aldous timing reconciled. Book One Ch. 26 is his first visit to the ward in nine years. From then on he visits weekly, and B4's signature moment is his *last* visit.

A☐

Geography stays consistent:

Lowside sits on the old seabed. It is half-burned (B5), flooded (B6) and becomes a harbour ward (B7).

The Gate of Coldbank stands at the 856 collapse site.

The Tear becomes a bay.

A☐

Every book resolves its own central conflict:

B2: the Tithe fails and the Seal is exposed.

B3: the expedition returns and the map is published.

B4: the mining halt is voted.

B5: the war ends at Harl.

B6: the Vent is stabilised.

B7: the Return is completed.

Series consequences carry the momentum forward. A cliffhanger never stands in for a resolution.

A☐

Provisional elements are tracked in DECISIONS.md once adopted: Halvard, Rade, Strand, Coyle, Ennor, Taevo, Ostovar, Merrow, Tull, Saelor, the Ring's twelve shafts, the gentling, the brinewort draught, the Bell Shaft and related items.